



THE CHALLENGER CUP

In the ESL India Premiership's competitive gaming cauldron, some of India's most talented pro-gamers battled it out for CS:GO, Dota 2, Just Dance and Hearthstone glory

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At the ESL India Premiership's Challenger Cup held in Pune last month, we saw lots of guns, glory and shake-a-leg's. Thanks to the good guys at Nodwin Gaming, it was a professional gaming extravaganza unlike any other that the city had witnessed as the ESL India juggernaut crashed into town.

The two-day event was held in a sizable cultural hall in the city centre, attracting over 500 gaming fans who were willing to hang around and just watch some of India's best gamers battle it out in the competition at hand. Just to see a crowd of about 100 or so spectators sitting quietly – not distracted by their phones or chit-chatting idly – focusing as hard on the game as the pro gamers competing on stage was a revelation of sorts. This goes to show that the Indian gaming scene is evolving thick and fast, where an eager audience is already hooked on to gaming networks like Twitch.tv and are willing to travel away from the comforts of their gaming PCs and

spend a weekend huddled in a hall with like-minded gaming enthusiasts, enjoying just watching others play. This is a significant trend, and it's only going to rise as pro-gaming competitions increase in number.

Professional setup

Before we give you the skinny on who won and who lost at the Challenger Cup, we'd really like to impress upon Nodwin Gaming's professional execution of the whole event. The pro gaming machines were setup in two different zones, ten-apiece – one each for DOTA 2 and CS:GO eliminations, respectively. Two zones of five gaming PCs were set up side-by-side on the podium where competing teams could sit, with a giant 30-feet widescreen behind displaying their game to the audience. The booths each had electronic boards at front displaying each team member's profile picture and name, just like you see in ESL games worldwide. The casters watched the game on their own personal 32-inch screen, kept aside to one corner of the

hall. And right next to the casters was the control room which monitored IT, video, audio and live-streaming of the Challenger Cup on ESL India Premiership's Twitch channel.

The only spoilsport in this whole apparatus that otherwise functioned very well was the lack of steady, consistent Internet connection in Pune, as most games suffered from packet drops and several forced pauses, much to the gamer's chagrin. What was great to see, however, was that despite all these minor technical glitches, most of ESL India Premiership's Challenger Cup went on smoothly, and in fact the CS:GO finale was actually showcased live for an hour on Twitch.tv's global homepage, clocking over 2200 simultaneous viewers at peak. Not bad, eh?

Who won, who lost?

Okay, enough of the setup and ambience, time to spill the beans on who won and who lost – surprise, there are no losers here! The ESL India Premiership Challenger Cup saw quarterfinals